

THE HANDOVER? Former Chhattisgarh CM Raman Singh (centre) with BJP state unit chief Arun Sao (extreme right)

BHUPESH KESHARWANI

BJP IN CHHATTISGARH

A SAFFRON FACELIFT

By Rahul Noronha

A new state unit chief. A new leader of opposition. A new incharge of the state. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has seen radical changes in its organisational structure in Chhattisgarh since August, with three new men commandeering its efforts to bring the party back into power as the state prepares for the assembly election scheduled in a little over a year.

After having an uninterrupted 15-year reign led by then chief minister Raman Singh, the BJP faced a humiliating defeat at the hands of the Congress in the last assembly election in 2018—winning just 15 of the 90 seats, and later losing one more to the Congress in a byelection. It is against this backdrop that the party's central leadership has initiated a major rejig in the state unit. It began with Arun Sao, who was elected to the Lok Sabha from the Bilaspur seat in 2019, being appointed the Chhattisgarh BJP president in early August, replacing former Union minister Vishnudeo Sai. A few days later, Dharamlal Kaushik made way for Narayan Chandel to be appointed as the leader of the opposition in the state assembly. Within a month, BJP veteran Om Mathur was named the party's Chhattisgarh in-charge, replacing D. Purandeswari.

The organisational overhaul has one clear motive—winning over the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), who comprise over 40 per cent of the state's population and have shown a tilt towards the Congress. While Sao is from the Sahu community, which is said to be the largest OBC group in the state, Chandel belongs to the Kurmi community, also an OBC. However, there have been murmurs, which are only growing louder by the day, that the BJP is trying to bet on leaders other than those close to Raman Singh, the former three-time CM and party's tallest figure in the state. Both Sai and Kaushik were said to have Singh's backing.

The Chhattisgarh BJP has gone for a leadership rejig a year ahead of the assembly polls. But can it ignore former three-time CM Raman Singh?

That the BJP wanted to infuse fresh blood in Chhattisgarh after the 2018 poll debacle was evident even three years back, when all 10 sitting MPs, including Raman Singh's son Abhishek, were denied tickets to contest the 2019 general election. So, it came as no surprise when Sao, one of the new faces in whom the party showed faith back then, was now chosen to head the state unit. "By appointing leaders who are not considered close to Raman Singh, the central leadership has given a clear message that it is keen to explore new options," explains a state-level party functionary. He, however, feels that the former CM's innings in the state's politics is not over just yet. "Actually, a lot depends on the new appointees—whether they can take along everyone in the party and emerge as true leaders."

However, a large section of party workers see the change of guard as a move to sideline Singh, so much so that when he recently went to Delhi for a minor surgery, rumours were rife back home that he was being given a gubernatorial assign-